

Module 3: Colonial Education and the Early Republic

EDUC 219 - Howard University

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Table of contents

1	Module overview	1
2	Guiding questions	1
3	Key concepts	2
4	Readings and activities	2

1 Module overview

This module examines education in the colonial period and the Early Republic. We will consider Indigenous education, colonial schooling, slavery, literacy, religion, family and community learning, and the early development of public education in the United States.

The module asks students to examine how education and schooling were shaped by colonization, race, power, labor, citizenship, religion, and economic development. We will also consider how Black communities, Indigenous communities, and other groups created, protected, and advanced educational practices and institutions under conditions of exclusion and constraint.

2 Guiding questions

- What forms of education existed before and alongside colonial schools?
- How did colonization shape Indigenous education, knowledge systems, languages, and communities?
- How did slavery, racial hierarchy, and restrictions on literacy shape educational opportunity?
- What roles did families, religious institutions, communities, and informal networks play in education?
- How did early public education develop, and who was included or excluded from it?
- How do colonial and early national histories help us understand later struggles over citizenship, schooling, literacy, and equal access?

3 Key concepts

- Indigenous education and knowledge systems
- Colonialism and settler colonialism
- Schooling, literacy, and religion
- Enslavement and anti-literacy laws
- Race, labor, citizenship, and social hierarchy
- Family, community, and informal education
- Early public education
- Educational access and exclusion
- Historical artifacts and primary sources

4 Readings and activities

- Givens (2021), Chapter 3
- Additional readings and media on Canvas
- Archival research presentations and findings
- Historical-timeline and database contributions
- Trial-group historical-context research

Trial connection

This module provides important historical context for later course work on *Plessy v. Ferguson* and *Brown v. Board of Education*. As you encounter events, laws, institutions, and historical artifacts, consider how they may help explain later systems of segregation, citizenship, unequal access, public education, and legal struggle.